

ROUGH CUT KAVEREE BAMZAI

Babloid Babus



It is a truth not universally acknowledged that English-speaking journalists have always regarded Hindi journalists as lesser mortals. Though the Hindi news channel boom changed all that, forcing even Oxbridge-educated star anchors to speak the language of the hinterland, that disdain remains. And nowhere is it more prominent than in the reaction to the draft Broadcasting Bill and the content code. With the Government holding up the threat of banning channels and controlling content, suddenly there is a division between English and Hindi news channels. From the two meetings that the I&B Ministry has held with industry representatives, it is clear that English news channels have taken the higher moral ground. They are not the babloid channels (the babble-laden version of tabloid channels), who carry stories of weddings of dwarfs and boys possessed by cobras. They are the responsible agenda-setting, opinion-making networks, heard by governments and preferred by policy makers.

Yes, Hindi news channels have created an alternative universe, peopled by freaks, fringe lunatics and fanboys. There are chair-swinging babas, men who celebrate birthdays in crematoriums and other men who meet Yamraj. While English news channels discuss the state of the nation, Hindi news channels discuss the state of Rakhi Sawant. Yet one thing unites them all—Sanjay Dutt's blue shirt. This week, all channels went into overdrive on why he was wearing a white shirt (and not a blue one), why he rolled down the window pane of his car as he left his home, how he slept, and whom he talked to. A few months ago, it was Abhishek and Aishwarya's wedding, which saw every channel discussing Aishwarya's lehnga and Karan Johar's thumbka.

So what's the point? Simple. News has been redefined across all channels, no matter the language. Trivialisation is just a matter of degree. English news channels may draw the line at mating monkeys and deviant donkeys (okay, I made that one up), but they are equally interested in Monica Bedi's future and in Shilpa Shetty's past. If the industry itself is seen to be divided on the issue of regulation (it should be applied to the "irresponsible" Hindi channels and not to the "public-spirited" English networks) only the Government will benefit. Because if the content code holds forth on tabloid tactics like door-stepping celebrities, it also has a point of view on sting operations. The television industry may be selective in its reaction to the Broadcasting Bill, but the Government will certainly not be, in its implementation.



SEEDHI BAAT ON AAJ TAK

"With success you make enemies"

ACTOR SHILPA SHETTY SPOKE TO EDITOR PRABHU CHAWLA about her life, her reality show and her offscreen roles

Q. You've been through many ups and downs.

A. Yes. Ups and downs are a part of life.

Q. Your past efforts to be successful have been in vain. But this time you've proved yourself.

A. It was not contrived, it was my destiny. I had no role in it. God thought I deserved it and He gave it to me.

Q. What has influenced your talent?

A. Talent has a positive and negative effect. As a public figure you have to act responsibly.

Q. Has your status of an international icon, helped you in films?

A. The most important thing is the change of perception towards me. I have got a lot of love from people all over the world. Now I am being appreciated because people of India feel that I have made them proud.

Q. You got an invitation from the Queen of London.

A. It was a special occasion. I was invited on Commonwealth Day where I talked about racism and AIDS.

Q. What about the reality show you did?

A. I never dreamt of winning. I didn't want to win. I went because I thought it was an interesting opportunity to end the misconception about the Indians in the West. I was offered a lot of money.

Q. How did you get the show?

A. Through a friend. When you're successful you make enemies. People I trusted as friends let me down.

Q. What was Bollywood's response after the show?

A. It was positive. They have found an internationally acclaimed actor from whom they can benefit. I am more visible now. And that will work in my favour.

Q. Are you a glamour girl or an item girl?

A. I'm a simple girl. I am an actor by profession.

Q. When will you marry?

A. I don't have time for romance. But I'd like to marry someone who's not from this industry.

Q. Who's the sexiest actor and actress in Hollywood?

A. Tom Cruise and Angelina Jolie.

Q. What is your dream as an actress?

A. I want to make my country proud. I want India to be talked about with respect.

Seedhi Baat is telecast on Aaj Tak at 8.30 p.m. every Sunday and 3.30 p.m. every Monday

Full text of the interview at:

<http://www.indiatoday.com>



SHIRYA PATIL